Claudia Marangon

cmarangon@fas.harvard.edu
https://claudiamarangon.github.io/
+393401551294

Harvard University
1727 Cambridge Street
Cambridge, MA 02138

Academic Positions

Harvard University
Postdoctoral Fellow (2025-)

Education

ETH Zurich
Ph.D. in Economics (2019-2025)

Bocconi University
M. Sc., Economic and Social Sciences, *110/110 Cum Laude* (2016-2019)
B. Sc., Economic and Social Sciences, *110/110 Cum Laude* (2013-2016)

Harvard Kennedy School
Visiting Fellow (Spring 2023)

Fields

Political Economy, Economics of Crime

References

Elliott Ash
ETH Zurich
elliott.ash@gess.ethz.ch

Marco Tabellini
Harvard Business School
mtabellini@hbs.edu

Dominik Hangartner
ETH Zurich
dominik.hangartner@gess.ethz.ch

Job Market Paper

Identity in Journalism: Evidence from News Reporting of Violence Against Women

Abstract: Does it matter who writes the news? I study this question by looking at gender differences in reporting on violence against women in Italy. Matching the universe of murders with female victims in 2006–2022 to newspaper articles, I construct indexes for two reporting narratives: victim-centered narratives, which focus on the victim and the violence she experienced and point to support resources, and perpetrator-centered narratives, which focus on motives such as jealousy or a fit of rage. I show that female journalists use more victim-centered and fewer perpetrator-centered narratives, exploiting the conditionally random assignment of reporters to crimes within newsrooms to account for selection in the stories covered. Combining reporter assignment with province-level readership in a staggered difference-in-differences design, I show that greater exposure to female reporters after a murder raises calls to the national helpline for violence against women. An online experiment sheds light on the mechanism: victim-centered narratives shift norms around help-seeking. It also reveals potential engagement costs, as these narratives decrease engagement among men but help retain female readers. The characteristics of those who report the news are thus a relevant supply-side determinant of both news content and reader behavior.

Working Papers

Judging Disparities: Recidivism Risk, Image Motives, and In-Group Bias on Wisconsin Criminal Courts
with E. Ash

Abstract: This paper studies racial in-group disparities in Wisconsin, which has one of the highest Black-to-White incarceration rates among all U.S. states. The analysis is motivated by a model in which a judge may want to incarcerate more due to three factors: (1) taste-based preferences about the defendant's group identity; (2) higher recidivism risk where the defendant is more likely to commit future crimes; and (3) image motives stemming from the defendant being in the same group as the judge. Further, a judge may have better information on recidivism risk due to two factors: (4) becoming more experienced, and (5) sharing the same group as

the defendant. We take these ideas to new data on 1 million cases from Wisconsin criminal courts, 2005-2021. Looking at racial disparities between majority (White) and minority (Black) judges and defendants, we find no evidence for anti-out-group bias (1). Using a recidivism risk score that we construct using machine learning tools to predict reoffense, we find evidence that judges do tend to incarcerate defendants with a higher recidivism risk (2). Consistent with judge experience leading to better information on defendant recidivism risk (4), we find that more experienced judges are more responsive in jailing defendants with a high recidivism risk score. Consistent with image motives (3), we find that when the minority group is responsible for most crimes, minority-group judges are harsher on their in-group. Finally, consistent with judges having better information on recidivism risk for same-group defendants (5), we find that judges are more responsive to the recidivism risk score for defendants from the same group when that group makes up a relatively small share of defendants.

Visual Justice: Racial Representation in Mugshot Coverage of U.S. Crime News
with E. Ash, S. Galletta, and B. Kohler

Abstract: This paper studies the visual representation of crime in U.S. news and whether policies aimed at protecting the identity of arrested individuals affect crime reporting. We assemble 3.46 million crime articles published by 1,848 outlets between 2015 and 2024 and measure their images with a face-level pipeline that detects mugshots, infers race, and links the same individual across articles. Benchmarking against FBI arrest records, we show that Black arrestees are over-represented in mugshot coverage relative to their share of arrests, and the gap is concentrated in high-volume, low-severity offenses such as DUI and drug crimes, where publishing any given booking photograph is discretionary. We then exploit staggered state restrictions on mugshot disclosure in a difference-in-differences design. The bans reduce mugshot publication by about a third and compress the over-representation of Black arrestees where it was largest. Next, we investigate whether crime reporting also adjusts to the removal of mugshots. Using the same design, we show that outlets replace booking photographs with other images, cover fewer arrests and more investigations, and also write about crime differently. Finally, we provide preliminary evidence that reducing mugshot use affects crime perceptions by reducing the salience of crime.

What's in a Name? The Effect of Social Proximity in Sentencing Decisions
with E. Ash

Abstract: This paper investigates how social proximity between judges and defendants influences sentencing outcomes in Wisconsin criminal courts. Moving beyond race and gender, we use name similarity as a novel measure of shared social background. We construct FastText embeddings of defendants appearing in more than 1 million cases (2005–2021) using defendants from the same street as context, and compute cosine similarity between their name vectors and those of their assigned judges. Leveraging the random assignment of judges to cases within courts, we find that higher judge-defendant name similarity reduces the probability of incarceration and sentence length, suggesting that social background similarity plays a meaningful role in explaining heterogeneity in sentencing outcomes. To investigate whether these differences are driven by taste-based or statistical discrimination, we propose a model of judicial decision-making that incorporates taste-based preferences and information about the defendants' risk of re-offending. Assuming that the precision of information signals increases with both judicial experience and similarity to the defendant, the model predicts that judges will be more responsive to defendants' recidivism risk in these scenarios. We test this hypothesis using a machine learning-predicted measure of defendants' recidivism risk, and we show that more experienced judges and those judging defendants with higher name similarity respond more to recidivism risk signals.

Conference Publications

WCLD: Curated Large Dataset of Criminal Cases from Wisconsin Circuit Courts
with E. Ash, N. Goel, N. Li, and P. Sun
Proceedings of the 37th Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems (2023)

Selected Work in Progress

AI in Newsrooms
with G. Torchetti

Teaching

Lecturer

Data Science for Public Policy: From Econometrics to AI, ETH Zurich, 2025
Text Data in Business and Economics, University of Basel, 2023–2024
Guest Lecturer, Big Data and Public Policy (CAS in Technology and Public Policy), 2022

Teaching Assistant

Building a Robot Judge: Data Science for Decision Making, ETH Zurich, 2020–2023
NLP for Law and Political Economy, ETH Zurich, 2020–2022
Experimental Economics and Psychology, Bocconi University, 2018

Grants and Awards

UniCredit Foundation Award for Best Paper in Gender Economics, 2026
SNSF Postdoc.Mobility Grant (CHF 136000), 2025–2027
ETH CIS Research Grant (CHF 7680), 2024
ETH Zurich Doc.Mobility Fellowship (CHF 7500), 2023

Affiliations

ETH Zurich Center for Law and Economics, Research Affiliate (2025-)
ETH Zurich Public Policy Group, Research Affiliate (2025-)
ETH Zurich AI Center (2021-2025)

Professional Activities

Conferences and Seminars

2026 *(including scheduled)***:** Workshop on Gender Stereotypes in the Media and Women in Leadership Positions; Harvard Political Economy Workshop; CEPR Workshop on Media, Technology, Politics, and Society; SIOE Annual Meeting; EEA Annual Meeting; Stanford Institute for Theoretical Economics Conference, Gender; APSA Annual Meeting; Harvard Alberto Alesina Political Economy Seminar; Annual Gender Equality Workshop

2025: Zurich Political Economy Seminar Series; 1st Workshop IdEP in Sustainable Economics; 2025 Petralia Workshop; Zurich Workshop in AI & Economics *(Poster)*; EuroWEPS; Milano Rookie Conference

2024: NBER Summer Institute, Economics of Crime; NICEP Conference; 15th Transatlantic Workshop in Economics of Crime; Conference for Empirical Legal Studies; II Political Economy Winter Workshop *(Poster)*; Zurich Political Economy Seminar Series

2023: ALEA Annual Meeting; Harvard Graduate Student Workshop in Political Economy and Culture; 6th Monash-Warwick-Zurich Text-as-Data Workshop; Rebecca B. Morton Conference on Experimental Political Science *(Poster)*; WEC.Jr; Narratives, Memory, and Beliefs Summer School and Workshop *(Poster)*; Zurich Political Economy Seminar Series; Zurich Workshop in Narratives in Economics

2022: Zurich Political Economy Seminar Series

2021: Zurich Political Economy Seminar Series; Summer Institute in Machine Learning in Economics, University of Chicago Booth School of Business *(summer school)*

Academic Service
Co-Organizer: Online Seminar in Economics + Data Science, 2023-

Refereeing: The Economic Journal, Journal of Law and Economics

Other Skills

Languages Italian: Native Speaker; English: Proficient; French: High Intermediate; German: Beginner
Programming Languages and Software: Python (Excellent), HTML/CSS (Good), R (Excellent), JavaScript (Good), C++ (Basic), SQL (Basic), STATA (Excellent), Matlab (Good)